Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for white when we want **to take a breath**, or when we need **to correct or soften**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

Fear of the first stroke

An empty canvas looks perfect. Then you are supposed to come and do something on it. The first coloured mark does not exist yet and already carries the responsibility for the whole picture.

If a white surface binds you, start on a smaller paper, make a mark by the edge or lightly rub the canvas with a thin tint. **The point is not to overpower yourself.** The point is to find a beginning from which you can continue.

Smaller paper.

Ordinary paper that you need not show anyone.

A mark by the edge.

The first stroke off centre.

A thin layer.

The canvas lightly tinted so that it is not so white.

A long exhale.

Before you begin, just breathe and look for a while.

Music or silence.

Which helps you more to put judgement aside?

Two papers.

One for trying and one for real.

White in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A white area is not automatically a message of emptiness or purity. It can mean calm, light, a pause, dissolved contrast or just that the paper stayed paper. A white picture can be full of happening.

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Leaving a white spot is not a mistake

Perhaps you feel a need to fill every part of the picture, because otherwise it looks unfinished. Try leaving one place free for a while.

Does it attract you? Disturb you? Do you feel the picture has gained space? Or do you really want to continue? You need not defend an unpainted spot. And you need not keep it just because it is called airiness.

Imagine the same empty spot in three pictures. In the first it is a breath, in the second a forgotten corner, in the third an invitation. **The colour has not changed. What you do with it has.**

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Covering is not the same as erasing

With white you can cover an older layer, soften it or let it partly show through. Sometimes covering is a relief. At other times you find you keep correcting something that a moment ago still seemed alive to you.

From a white repaint one cannot read that you reject the past. On a later look back, though, you may be curious what the covering was like for you.

Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

An area, a line, or an overlay?

A white line on a dark ground can join. A large area can create space and emptiness. While working you need not decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant relief for you, or just the pleasure of a clean surface.

- **WEIGHT**

Light, or lifeless?

If white feels pleasantly light to you, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If the area is too sharp, add a trace of ochre, brown or pink. If everything blends, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or translucency.

- **COURAGE**

You need not finish at once

Courage in painting does not have to mean that you must intervene in everything at once. If you want to leave an area free, try a few strokes in another direction or a relief. If you keep covering earlier layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a white stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning.** That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

- **I'm afraid of spoiling the canvas**
  Make a few marks on ordinary paper that you need not show anyone.
- **The picture feels overcrowded to me**
  Try a small light area or a translucent overlay.
- **White is too sharp**
  Add a trace of ochre, brown or pink.
- **I keep correcting everything**
  Put the brush down for a while and look from a greater distance.

Do you want to paint only with white? Try relief, layers, different directions of strokes and the difference between a matte and a glossy surface.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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